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FIRST MEETING OF PARLIAMENT AFTER DHARMENDRA PRADHAN'S RESIGNATION AS EDUCATION MINISTER

Deadlock nears end, LS all set to discuss anti-paper leak Bill today

Speaker, Govt floor managers reach out to Opp; 6 hours kept for discussion, may be extended

Deeptiman Tiwary, Damini Nath, Harikishan Sharma & Amrita Nayak Dutta
New Delhi, July 27

AFTER A week of repeated disruptions, the government and the Opposition on Monday reached an understanding to end the logjam in Lok Sabha, paving the way for a discussion on The Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Amendment Bill, 2026, from Tuesday.

This comes two days after Dharmendra Pradhan resigned as the Education Minister on Saturday, following over a month-long protest spearheaded by the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) over the NEET(UG) question paper leak.

The breakthrough on Monday came after a day of behind-the-scenes negotiations led by Speaker Om Birla and government floor managers even as both Houses were repeatedly adjourned amid the Opposition's protests against the alleged police excesses during the student protests.

Sources said Birla, who repeatedly appealed in the House for a discussion on the Bill, personally reached out to floor

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Former Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan being welcomed by NDA MPs at Parliament, Monday. PTI

INDIAN EXPRESS UPSC IAS EDITION HD 28~07~2026
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"AVOID POLITICAL & IRRELEVANT ARTICLES"
Please Try To Read This Completely in 40 Minutes If You Can't So Then You Have To Increase Your Efforts
All the topics of this UPSC IAS Edition are directly or indirectly important for the prelims & main examination.
There are some topics which can be coded in answer writing of other topics in the main exam.

Right to peaceful protest guaranteed, police excesses can be examined: SC

'All injuries to individuals, be it police officer or protesters, are of equal concern'

Ananthakrishnan G & Apurva Vishwanath
New Delhi, July 27

STATING THAT there cannot be police excesses or violence merely because there is an agitation, the Supreme Court on Monday underlined the need for a "balanced" approach, a pan-India "protocol" and a "self-evolved discipline, which is integral to the democratic process".

The three-judge bench, presided over by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant, was hearing a clutch of petitions, including one by RJD Rajya Sabha MP Manoj Jha, alleging police excesses against protesters in Delhi's Jantar Mantar and elsewhere.

"Right to protest, peaceful protest, lawful protest, is abso-

lutely guaranteed under the constitutional scheme. So long as there is a peaceful agitation, merely because there is an agitation, there can't be excesses," CJI Surya Kant said.

"There should be a protocol in place. If they want to agitate on an issue... They should be provided with proper space... There should be no restriction or impediment in that. But if there is someone else, some anti-social element, or somebody has done anything wrong, that of course can be taken care of," the CJI said.

The CJI advised all sides not to adopt an adversarial approach. "If there are excesses committed, yes, those should be independently looked into. (It) should be examined that who are the persons responsible?"

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Ministry pushing RBI to open licences for more urban co-op banks: Secy

Harikishan Sharma
New Delhi, July 27

THE MINISTRY of Cooperation has urged the RBI to open licences for more urban cooperative banks in the country, a top official said Monday.

Speaking at a book release function, Cooperation Ministry Secretary Ashish Kumar Bhutani said that India needs urban cooperative banks (UCBs) in every town of the country.

Echoing the views, Satish K Marathe, Director, Central Board of RBI, said there are hundreds of districts in the country that do not have UCBs.

“Of the 1,450 UCBs in the country, almost 1,100 are in Real Creator IAS Edition https://t.me/+2RvD_RGf9mljMzg1

three states — Maharashtra, Gujarat, and Karnataka. The rest of the country has very few (urban cooperative) banks,” Marathe said, speaking after the release of the book ‘*Cooperative Management: The Indian Perspective*’, co-authored by KK Tripathy, Joint Secretary in the Economic Advisory Council to The Prime Minister. Harekrishna Misra and SK Wadkar co-wrote the book.

Responding to Marathe’s remarks, Bhutani said, “This is one of the biggest, I would say, focus areas for the ministry... We are... agitating with Mr Marathe in RBI to open up licensing, bring in licensing policy for the UCBs.”

[FROM PAGE 1 | FULL REPORTS ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM]

Deadlock may end

leaders across party lines during a three-hour adjournment from 2 pm to 5 pm. Simultaneously, government floor managers engaged Opposition leaders.

By evening, both sides had agreed that the Bill would be taken up on Tuesday, with members expected to move amendments before the government replies. A senior Congress leader confirmed to *The Indian Express* that discussions had taken place to break the deadlock and the party had agreed to debate the Bill on Tuesday.

The breakthrough came after another day of washout in Parliament on Monday.

The day began with Opposition MPs protesting at Parliament’s Makar Dwar over two separate issues — police action against the protesters, and the Ram Temple donation row. Congress leaders Rahul Gandhi, Priyanka Gandhi Vadra and MPs from other INDIA bloc parties joined the demonstration before both Houses assembled.

In Lok Sabha, Opposition MPs rushed into the Well as soon as Question Hour began, demanding a statement from Union Home Minister Amit Shah. Amid repeated dis-

ruptions, Minister of State in the Prime Minister’s Office (PMO) Jitendra Singh introduced The Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Amendment Bill, 2026, around noon.

When the House met again at 2 pm, Birla made a fresh appeal for consensus, describing the Bill as legislation linked to the future of crores of students and saying it sought to curb paper leaks and organised examination fraud. Pointing out that members had submitted 91 amendments, he said six hours had been earmarked for discussion and more time could be allotted if required. He then adjourned the House until 5 pm to enable consultations between the Treasury and Opposition benches.

Parliamentary Affairs Minister Kiren Rijiju backed the Speaker’s appeal, questioning why the Opposition was blocking debate despite filing numerous amendments to the Bill.

However, when the House reassembled at 5 pm, Opposition members continued their protests. Rijiju accused the Congress and its allies of preventing discussion on legislation that they had themselves demanded after

the NEET controversy.

“All members have come well prepared. Several Opposition members have submitted amendments. Yet the Congress and its allies are deliberately preventing discussion on such an important Bill,” he said, adding that the country’s youth were watching Parliament and the Opposition should participate in the debate.

The Lok Sabha was subsequently adjourned for the day.

The Rajya Sabha witnessed similar scenes. Leader of Opposition Mallikarjun Kharge sought a discussion under Rule 267 on the police action against protesters, but Chairman CP Radhakrishnan rejected the notice. Opposition members demanded statements from Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Home Minister Amit Shah, leading to repeated adjournments through the day.

When the House reassembled after lunch, Minister of State for Home Nityananda Rai moved the Prevention of Insults to National Honour (Amendment) Bill, 2026, for consideration before fresh protests stalled proceedings again.

Later, Deputy Chairman Harivansh attempted to take up the Bill for discussion. Rijiju again appealed to the Opposition to let the House function,

while Kharge maintained that the Opposition was ready for a debate but insisted that Shah first make a statement on the police action. Amid slogan-shouting by both sides, the Rajya Sabha, too, was adjourned for the day.

The Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Amendment Bill, 2026, amends the Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Act, 2024. The new Bill provides for jail term up to 10 years, up from three to five years in the 2024 Act, and penalty up to Rs 50 lakh instead of the earlier Rs 10 lakh. If the crime is found to be organised, the Bill proposes a minimum sentence of seven years and a penalty of up to Rs 10 crore.

It also sets a two-month deadline to complete investigations into paper leak cases. According to the Bill, States and Union Territories will be empowered to set up fast-track courts that can complete the trial within three months of filing of the chargesheet. The Centre, it says, will be empowered to set up a special task force to probe some paper leak cases.

On Sunday, Prime Minister Narendra Modi also announced a high-powered task force on exam reforms led by Infosys co-founder Nandan Nilekani.

Right to peaceful protest: SC

What kind of excesses have been committed? What are the preventive measures and mandatory guidelines to ensure (such incidents are not repeated)?” he said.

The bench, also comprising Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana, fixed Tuesday to hear the petitions. Although the

bench had initially fixed Monday to hear two of these petitions, counsels for some fresh petitioners requested that they be heard as well.

Advocate Fauzia Shakeel, appearing for Jha, referred to the alleged police firing on protesters in Bihar. “Our petition has comprehensive information

along with the use of AK-47 in Siwan yesterday. That has all the updated data,” she said.

Senior Advocate Sridhar Potaraju, representing families of police personnel allegedly attacked by protesters, sought to be heard, too. “We would like to participate, present our perspective,” he said, urging the court,

“protect these police as well in uniform”. Stating that there was “no question of defending excesses”, Potaraju argued for the “rights of the policemen in uniform” who “are subject to discipline”. “There are videos circulating. They have been kicked, lynched literally,” he said.

Justice Bagchi said the matter would have to be looked at holistically and that “all injuries to individuals, be it a police officer or protestors, are of equal

concern”. He said the court would “call upon the state to explain why adequate state funds were not given to police to deal with these large demonstrations”, for protective gear like helmets, etc. “We would like to present that perspective,” Potaraju said.

Senior Advocate Vikas Singh said, “Actually, Your Lordships will have to pass an all-India order. This is a problem in the entire country.”

EXPRESSspecial

Probe sought into luxury housing project at Morphological Ridge

Sophiya Mathew
New Delhi, July 27

HAVE ALL environmental regulations been followed? Has any unauthorised cutting of Ridge formations taken place? Has excavation exceeded approved limits? These are among the questions raised by a panel overseeing key matters related to ecologically-sensitive Delhi's Morphological Ridge as it sought a comprehensive inquiry into the construction activities at a luxury housing project.

Constituted last month by LG Taranjit Singh Sandhu, in compliance with the Supreme Court directives, the Standing Committee of the Delhi Ridge Management Board (SCDRMB) conducted a site inspection for a RR Texknit LLP project in the area on July 20. In a letter to the Deputy Conservator of Forests (South) dated July 22, the panel sought an inquiry into the project by the Forest department and said it observed "large-scale excavation" and "cutting of ridge" for the construction of a basement. The SCDRMB has sought a detailed report within 10 days.

The Morphological Ridge refers to areas outside the notified Ridge that have similar physical and ecological features.



The site under inspection. EXPRESS

The Delhi High Court and subsequently the Supreme Court have held that such areas must receive the same protection as notified Ridge areas. Construction in these areas has, therefore, been subject to the requisite clearances from the Ridge Management Board and permission and the SC.

The SCDRMB has asked the Forest department to examine all aspects of the project, including its statutory permissions, approvals, clearances, licences and no objection certificates. It has specifically sought verification of whether the excavation exceeded approved limits in terms of depth, area or volume, and whether any part of the construction or excavation encroached upon the Morphological Ridge or any protected area beyond the approved limits.

The inquiry will also examine if there was any unauth-

orised cutting of Ridge formations, alteration of natural drainage, removal of vegetation or damage to adjoining land, as well as compliance with environmental safeguards, dust suppression measures, transportation norms and waste management requirements.

RR Texknit, however, has denied that it is carrying out any mining activity. In a preliminary reply to a notice issued by the Sub-Divisional Magistrate (Mehrauli) in April over alleged illegal excavation or mining at its project site in B-1, Vasant Kunj, the company said the excavation was incidental to foundation and basement construction and did not constitute "mining operations" under the Mines and Minerals (Development and Regulation) Act, 1957.

The firm stated that it was undertaking construction in accordance with applicable laws and permissions, including an MCD-sanctioned building plan dated March 22, 2024, Environmental Clearance and approvals from agencies concerned. It also said the project had been examined in proceedings connected with a SC case.

RR Texknit has also maintained that the excavation is being carried out as per sanctioned plans and approved structural designs, under the

supervision of qualified engineers and with safety measures including shoring and stabilisation. The company has also said that the excavated material is being transported to authorised MCD construction and demolition waste disposal sites and has denied allegations of the sale or diversion of excavated material, describing such allegations as "vague" and "unsubstantiated".

The SCDRMB, meanwhile, has asked the Forest department to establish the total quantity of earth and rock excavated from the site and reconcile it with the quantity transported to the locations disclosed by the project proponents. It has sought verification through weighbridge records, transportation challans, GPS records where available, invoices, receipts and vehicle movement details.

The committee has also raised concerns over whether a Geotechnical Impact Assessment was required for the project. Its letter states that a geotechnical investigation appeared to have been carried out while preparing the Soil Testing Report, but that no Geotechnical Impact Assessment had been undertaken so far. The Forest department has been asked to examine if such an assessment was required.

Gadkari can sue Meta, X over AI deepfakes on E20: Bombay HC

Omkar Gokhale
Mumbai. July 27

UNION TRANSPORT Minister Nitin Gadkari can file a civil suit against Meta platforms, X Corp, Google LLC, and others over allegedly defamatory AI-generated deepfake videos and manipulated digital content linked to the ethanol-blended fuel controversy, the Bombay High Court ruled on Monday.

The suit seeks the removal of “defamatory” content, which, according to Gadkari, “falsely” associates him with the Ethanol Blended Petrol (EBP) programme and the E20 initiative. According to his plea, both are administered exclusively by the Union Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas, and Gadkari has no role in either programme.

Justice Abhay Ahuja allowed Gadkari, represented by advocate Sandeep S Ladda, to institute the suit in the Bombay High Court. The court will hear his application for interim relief, including a temporary injunction on Tuesday.

The Union Ministries of Electronics and Information Technology and Telecommunications have also been named as respondents. In the suit, Gadkari said purpose of his civil suit against Meta Platforms, X Corp, Google LLC and others was not to prevent public discussion or criticism of his actions or government policies.

“The purpose and object of filing the suit is not to curtail or prevent the public at large from engaging in discussion, debate, analysis or fair, just and bona fide criticism of any decision taken by the plaintiff himself or by his office,” the plea said.

It added that Gadkari “does not seek to stifle or restrain fair criticism, dissent, debate or bona fide expression of opinion concerning his public life, governmental policies or official functions”. The defamatory and deepfake content published by defendant platforms are “false, fabricated and defamatory with respect of the plaintiff”.

The suit argues the content in question is “ex facie false, fabricated, malicious, abusive and



Union Road Transport and Highways Minister Nitin Gadkari during the Monsoon session of Parliament in New Delhi on Monday. PTI

grossly defamatory”, and that the deepfake videos amount to an unauthorised use of Gadkari’s personality and publicity rights without his consent.

It says, “Plaintiff has no role or nexus whatsoever with EBP or the E20 initiative, which is administered exclusively by the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas. The Defamatory Content, insofar as it consists of profane and abusive language directed at the Plaintiff, falls outside the ambit of legitimate political criticism or satire. The Deep Fake Content constitutes

an unauthorised exploitation of the Plaintiffs personality and publicity rights. That the balance of convenience lies in favour of the Plaintiff, who continues to suffer irreparable harm to his reputation not compensable in terms of money.”

In his plea, Gadkari has alleged that some unknown persons circulated posts and deepfake content, falsely portraying him as personally responsible for the EBP and E20 initiatives. The suit claimed these posts also allege that he and his family had financially benefited from it.

Gadkari claimed the objectionable content “falsely portrays” plaintiff as personally responsible for the decisions and falsely allege that he and/or his family have “derived undue pecuniary benefit from the programme, insinuating corruption, conflict of interest and abuse of office”.

The suit calls the allegations false and designed to create a misleading impression that Gadkari misused his public office for private gain, causing irreparable harm to his reputation. It seeks directions to the defendants to remove, disable and stop the circulation of the allegedly defamatory and manipulated content.

After Gadkari dismissed claims that EBP damages vehicles, saying manufacturers had attributed the reported breakdowns to contaminated or non-standard fuel, the BJP’s Nagpur social media cell chief filed a complaint accusing several influencers of spreading misinformation and using abusive, defamatory language against the minister.

SC seeks Centre’s reply on Sibal plea over Tenth Schedule interpretation

Express News Service
New Delhi, July 27

THE SUPREME Court on Monday sought the centre’s response on a plea by Senior Advocate Kapil Sibal questioning the interpretation of the Tenth Schedule to the Constitution which deals with disqualification for defection.

Issuing notice to the centre, a bench of Justices P.S. Narasimha and Alok Aradhe however wondered if it’s not an issue for the Parliament to deal with.

The plea contends that the current interpretation gives splinter groups room to escape the anti-defection law by merging with other political parties.

Sibal told the bench that matter has consequences for polity as electoral majority can be turned into minority by resorting to mergers.

"Electoral verdict can be changed through this process. A majority can become minor-

ity and a minority can become majority”, he submitted and referred to the 2022 Goa case of 8 of 10 Congress MLAs merging with the BJP which is pending before the SC.

Justice Narasimha said, “these are issues typically to be raised before the floor of the house; if not, then at least before political parties. 10th Schedule is intended to regulate the mechanism between the legislators...What transpired in the working of the 10th Schedule, we have been seeing, enormous issues about the 10th Schedule.”

Sibal said that the ruling side will not allow it to be decided.

The SC is also seized of a plea by the Shiv Sena (Uddhav Bal Thackeray) faction challenging Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla’s decision approving the merger of six of its MPs with the rival Shiv Sena led by Maharashtra Deputy Chief Minister Eknath Shinde.

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70% of suicides by Indians abroad in Gulf: MEA data

1,340 Indians have died by suicide in Gulf countries in the last three years

Divya A
New Delhi, July 27

OVER THE last three years, 1,340 Indian citizens died by suicide in Gulf countries, according to data provided by the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) in Parliament.

Out of these, 511 cases have been recorded in the United Arab Emirates (UAE), followed by Saudi Arabia (354), Kuwait (162), Oman (146), Bahrain (101) and Qatar (66).

The Ministry has pegged the total number of Indians abroad who have died by suicide between 2023 and 2025 at over 1,900. GCC (Gulf Cooperation Council) countries re-

•What is killing Indians abroad

	NATURAL REASONS	WORKPLACE ACCIDENTS	SUICIDE	CRIME	OTHER REASONS
Saudi Arabia	6,376	182	354	29	1,040
UAE	5,702	128	511	25	1,092
Kuwait	1,672	62	162	10	285
Oman	1,092	38	146	0	222
Qatar	783	23	66	0	102
Bahrain	703	10	101	2	43

YEARS: 2023-25; SOURCE: MEA

corded more than 70% of these cases, followed by Malaysia (131) and the United States (62). Italy, Canada and the United Kingdom recorded over 30 cases each in the three-year period.

Around one crore Indian citizens and persons of Indian origin are presently living in the Gulf countries. The figures were provided by Minister of State, External Affairs, Kirti Vardhan Singh, in Lok Sabha during the ongoing Parliament session. He was responding to

a question by Congress Parliamentarians Satpal Brahmachari and Jai Prakash on ‘review of death of Indian citizens abroad’. On an average, number of suicide cases by Indian citizens living abroad seems to have increased in the period cited. In 2022, the MEA had pegged the number between 2014 and 2022 at 4,005.

Even as no reason has been cited behind the increase in such cases, the minister said that “several measures and steps such as Pravasi Bhartiya

Bima Yojna (PBBY) have been taken by the Government of India to ensure the well-being and protection of Indian workers overseas”.

“The PBBY is a mandatory insurance scheme for all Emigration Check Required (ECR) category workers going to ECR countries,” Singh said. The scheme provides an insurance cover of Rs 10 lakh in case of accidental death or permanent disability besides other benefits at a nominal insurance premium of Rs 275 for two years or Rs 375 for three years.

The latest data also tabulates the deaths of Indian citizens by cause — natural causes, workplace accidents, suicide, crime and other reasons. GCC countries accounted for considerably high fatalities due to workplace accidents with Saudi Arabia recording 182 cases and UAE 128 cases. Total number of Indians abroad who have lost their lives in the last three years exceeds 39,000.

Western Ghats panel gets one more year as deadlock continues over eco-sensitive area

Nikhil Ghanekar
New Delhi, July 27

AN EXPERT committee constituted in 2022 by the Union environment ministry to examine issues raised by states regarding the demarcation of ecologically sensitive areas (ESAs) in the fragile Western Ghats region was given a year’s extension late last month, *The Indian Express* has learnt.

The extension was given as the committee’s and the Centre’s work on breaking the deadlock on finalising ESAs as demarcated in a July 2024 draft notification, which has lapsed, continues.

A July 31, 2024, draft notification, published on August 2 — which was a sixth iteration of the Western Ghats ESA demarcation — had declared 56,825.7 sq km of the Ghats as ESA, across Gujarat, Maharashtra, Goa, Karnataka, Tamil Nadu, and Kerala.

Under the 2024 draft, ESAs demarcated across states included 449 sq km in Gujarat, 17,340 sq km in Maharashtra, 1,461 sq km in Goa, 20,668 sq km in Karnataka, 6,914 sq km in Tamil Nadu, and 9,993.7 sq km in Kerala.

It is still unclear if the ministry plans to renotify a seventh draft notification immediately.

The Western Ghats is a 1,500 km long near-continuous mountain chain running from South Gujarat to Kerala, and is one of the world’s eight “hottest biodiversity hotspots”, harbouring unique plants and wildlife. The Western Ghats forests are home to nearly 2,000 species of plants,

84 fish species, 87 amphibian species, 89 reptile species, and 12 mammals found only in this region.

The expert committee is headed by Sanjay Kumar, a former director-general of forests at the ministry, and includes six other members from the fields of ecology, remote sensing, space application, geology, and ministry officials. It is learnt that the committee’s tenure was extended on June 30 till July 2027.

Even as the committee’s term has been extended, talks to finalise ESAs in Maharashtra, Goa, and Gujarat remain in advanced stages, two people aware of the developments said. *The Indian Express* reported last month that talks had advanced the most in the three states. Official sources said that this remains on track, and the committee is now appraising a revised proposal sent by Maharashtra in late June.

The expert committee also held a fresh round of consultation with the new Congress-led Kerala government recently, and several sticking points on finalising the area between 8,500 and 8,800 sq km are nearing resolution, people aware of developments said.

The Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change did not respond to queries seeking official comment on when the expert committee is likely to submit its final report on the ESA proposals of all state governments, and whether its terms of reference have been amended.

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Fixing exam system won't be enough. Bigger task is restoring trust



AMITABH MATTOO

THE APPOINTMENT of a high-powered task force by the Prime Minister to reform India's public examination system is welcome, and Nandan Nilekani is a natural choice to lead it. Having worked with him briefly on the National Knowledge Commission, I know he combines intellectual clarity with a rare ability to translate large ideas into workable institutions. He understands technology; he also understands that it must ultimately serve public trust. The man best equipped to build a technological fix is also perhaps the one most likely to warn that technology alone will not be enough.

India is still absorbing the enormity of what happened at Jantar Mantar. A youth-led protest compelled the resignation of the Union Education Minister and forced the government to concede that the crisis could not be managed through routine assurances. Ministerial resignations have become exceedingly rare; responsibility is usually dispersed until it disappears. This one represented the return, however briefly, of political accountability. Yet what the protesters exposed was larger than the fate of one minister. They exposed a crisis of trust.

As vice-chancellor of the University of Jammu for six years, I came to understand the almost sacred character of a public examination. The jurisdiction was vast — from Poonch and Rajouri to Doda and Kishtwar in the mountains — and lakhs of students appeared in its examinations, often travelling over hard terrain merely to reach a centre. For each of them, the integrity of the system was the foundation of their faith in the university. An examination is a covenant between the university and the student: The student submits to its discipline on the assumption that the institution will protect the

integrity of the process. Once that faith is broken, every mark becomes suspect, and every honest candidate diminished.

During my years as vice-chancellor, there was not a single leakage of a question paper. It was not because we possessed miraculous technology or it required "rocket science", but because we invested authority in officers of impeccable integrity. No one, not even the vice-chancellor, held unnecessary information; institutional integrity often depends on ensuring that those who do not need to know are not permitted to know.

There was only one occasion when an attempt was made to twist my arm. A serving cabinet minister wanted his doctor-aspirant daughter awarded the marks she needed to pass a paper. The request carried all the weight of political office. There was no question of yielding. Had one student been given undeserved marks, the injury would not have been confined to one examination. Every honest student would have been cheated, every conscientious teacher insulted, and the university's word emptied of meaning.

This is why the present crisis cannot be understood as a technical malfunction alone. Technology can secure databases, track the custody of papers and authenticate candidates, and Nilekani's task force can undoubtedly design a more robust architecture. But no digital system can compensate indefinitely for compromised appointments, weak institutions or the absence of moral courage. Technology cannot manufacture integrity.

For millions of Indian families, a competitive examination is often the narrowest bridge between in-

herited circumstances and a different future, for which parents exhaust savings and students surrender years to coaching rooms. I have lived that world: Cycling at six each winter morning to Gokul Nath's smoky room, where he taught a huddle of six or eight of us, his notes pressed through carbon paper into a copy for each — knowing that as a Kashmiri Pandit, I would have to fare better merely to have a chance. A leaked paper therefore inflicts more than procedural damage: It becomes the leakage of faith in the republic. That is what the young at Jantar Mantar understood more quickly than many in authority.

As dean of SIS at JNU, I work among students who question power almost instinctively. They can be perceptive, courageous and morally compelling; they can also be doctrinaire, theatrical and impatient with complexity. But youthful dissent should never be answered with condescension. I had learnt this much earlier in Srinagar, when the stone had become a form of political expression. Some of the young were driven by grievance, some by forces willing to exploit their anger; but nearly all believed that established institutions had stopped hearing them. I condemned stone-throwing then and do so unequivocally now. Yet treating every angry young person as a mere law-and-order problem is not strength but the abandonment of politics.

This is what makes Jantar Mantar significant. Gen Z did not invent anger; what distinguishes it is the speed with which private frustration becomes collective action.

The so-called Cockroach Janta Party was both comic and politically astute: A creature associated with neglect and extermination be-

came a symbol of survival — you may ridicule us or disperse us, but we will not disappear. Humour became resistance. The meme walked out of the mobile phone and occupied Jantar Mantar. But this moment should not be romanticised. Virality is not organisation; outrage is not policy. A movement can secure a resignation without possessing the institutional imagination to redesign an examination system. Gen Z can expose, mobilise and disrupt; it must now acquire the less glamorous capacity to remain engaged after the barricades are removed.

Nor should the government regard the task force as the end of the matter. Its recommendations must be made public, recruitment to examination bodies transparent, responsibility clearly assigned, and penalties swift. The new architecture must begin with a simple principle: Everyone entrusted with an examination must be chosen for integrity before efficiency, for independence before convenience.

The young at Jantar Mantar forced India to remember that democratic power is not invulnerable. The resignation of a Union minister was not a humiliation of democracy; it was democracy functioning as it should — citizens demanding an answer and political authority accepting consequence. The larger responsibility belongs to all of us who administer universities and educate the young. We cannot ask students to believe in merit or lecture them about patience while institutions repeatedly betray their trust. The task before the Nilekani committee is to create a leak-proof examination system. The task before the republic is larger: To become worthy once again of the faith of its young.

The writer is dean, School of International Studies, JNU

Nilekani panel mandate must be expansive

THE MORE than a month-long protests by the country's youth have brought long-overdue political attention to education reform. The Centre's decision to constitute a high-level task force, barely a day after Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation, is a necessary acknowledgement of the crisis of confidence in a system that determines the fate of millions of young Indians. The committee's composition — technology and education experts and former bureaucrats — suggests that the government is looking beyond immediate crisis management. Such an outlook is welcome. It is also heartening that the panel will be chaired by Nandan Nilekani, whose stewardship of Aadhaar and India's digital public infrastructure combined technological innovation with changes in institutional architecture on an unprecedented scale. His proven ability to bring together government, industry and civil society around far-reaching reforms should stand the task force in good stead as it confronts one of the most consequential public policy challenges the country faces.

The recent agitation may have been triggered by repeated examination failures, but at its heart lay a larger question: Does the country's education system open doors at a time when the world of work is undergoing profound transformations — AI is reshaping white-collar employment, automation is altering the skill-related demands of employers, and India's IT and outsourcing industries are entering a period of technological disruption. The youth face a double uncertainty — an examination system whose credibility has repeatedly been called into question and a labour market whose contours are rapidly changing. This is where Nilekani's presence on the panel assumes significance. He has maintained that investments in digital infrastructure, skilling and continuous learning can make AI a job multiplier. He has also argued that AI will reshape India's outsourcing industry, making it imperative for professionals to move towards higher-value expertise. Such insights can help the task force become a forum for sustained engagement with the changing knowledge economy.

For that to happen, the government should resist the temptation of framing the task force as a supra National Testing Agency (NTA) and instead treat its work as the starting point for broader reform. Its recommendations must be accompanied by clear timelines and measurable milestones. The government must be careful, too, to eschew the prevarication that followed the submission of the K Radhakrishnan committee report in 2024 — most of the major measures, including accountability, institutional restructuring and technological upgrades suggested by the panel formed after the NEET failure that year, have been unevenly implemented. The outrage that spilled onto the country's streets last week should be warning enough that the old ways will work no more.

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Trump & Netanyahu: The cracks are showing

ISRAELI PRIME Minister Benjamin Netanyahu's meeting with President Donald Trump this week comes at a time of growing strain in the US-Israel relationship. This is because of diverging interests over the war with Iran, Israel's military campaigns in Lebanon and Gaza, and signs that the personal rapport between the two leaders who face elections later this year is waning. Netanyahu has long presented his close ties with Trump as a political asset, while Trump confronts an electorate increasingly angry about the war. How each reconciles these competing pressures will shape the outcome of this meeting. The US-Saudi nuclear deal has also raised concerns in Israel that it could, over time, erode its strategic edge in the region and weaken its leverage in securing the normalisation of ties with Riyadh.

The US and Israel have been steadfast allies since the 1967 Six-Day War, their alliance is underpinned by strategic interests and what they perceive as shared democratic and Judeo-Christian values. That consensus appears to be fraying. With a new generation of Americans coming of age, Israel no longer commands the instinctive public backing it once enjoyed. Polls consistently show that support for Israel in America has fallen to historic lows amid the war in Gaza. The old bipartisan consensus on military aid is also weakening. Earlier this month, more than a hundred House Democrats voted to cut US military assistance to Israel, indicating a growing unease within the party even as New York City Mayor Zohran Mamdani called on the federal government to enforce the ICC's arrest warrant against Netanyahu. The Republican consensus on Israel will depend on the outcome of the war in Iran.

Ahead of the meeting, Netanyahu offered Trump significant concessions, including cooperation on a US-brokered security arrangement in southern Lebanon and cabinet approval for the entry of a multinational security force into Gaza under Trump's 20-point plan. Whether these will satisfy the US president remains to be seen. With sections of the American public increasingly sceptical of Washington's support for Israel, the question is how much more Trump will demand and how much more Netanyahu can concede as both prepare to face their electorates.

The Ideas Page

TUESDAY, JULY 28, 2026

India, Bangladesh must not just renew Ganga Treaty. They should reimagine it



SRINIVAS CHOKKAKULA

AS THE 30-year term of the 1996 Ganga Water Treaty between India and Bangladesh approaches its conclusion, discussions about its future are gathering momentum. Much of the public debate is about whether the treaty will be renewed or revised. But a more consequential question is, what kind of agreement will it be? The political, institutional and ecological conditions that produced the 1996 treaty are vastly different. The negotiations are likely to be about much more than water sharing at Farakka.

The 1996 treaty had a single-point agenda of water sharing, following India's decision to build the Farakka barrage. The treaty provided a flow-dependent water-sharing arrangement that includes a 50:50 pro-rata sharing when the flows at Farakka dip below a limit. Bangladesh has often expressed its dissatisfaction about not receiving its due share during the dry seasons.

The next Ganga Treaty is not likely to be restricted to this one specific transborder issue. It will transcend territories and borders, within and outside, enlarging the scope of negotiations. The negotiations will be challenging, especially given the new political realities in Bangladesh. But they can also offer new opportunities for robust water diplomacy and enduring relations between India and Bangladesh.

There are two reasons why the negotiations will have an expanded agenda.

First, politics have become more complex. The 1996 treaty, signed after decades of deliberations, reflected a particular political moment of relatively stable bilateral relations. The treaty emerged from sustained Track 1 and Track 2 engagements that built trust and goodwill. Today, the negotiations are likely to be shaped as much by domestic political dynamics as by bilateral diplomatic considerations. Dhaka will find it challenging to navigate the antagonistic sentiment

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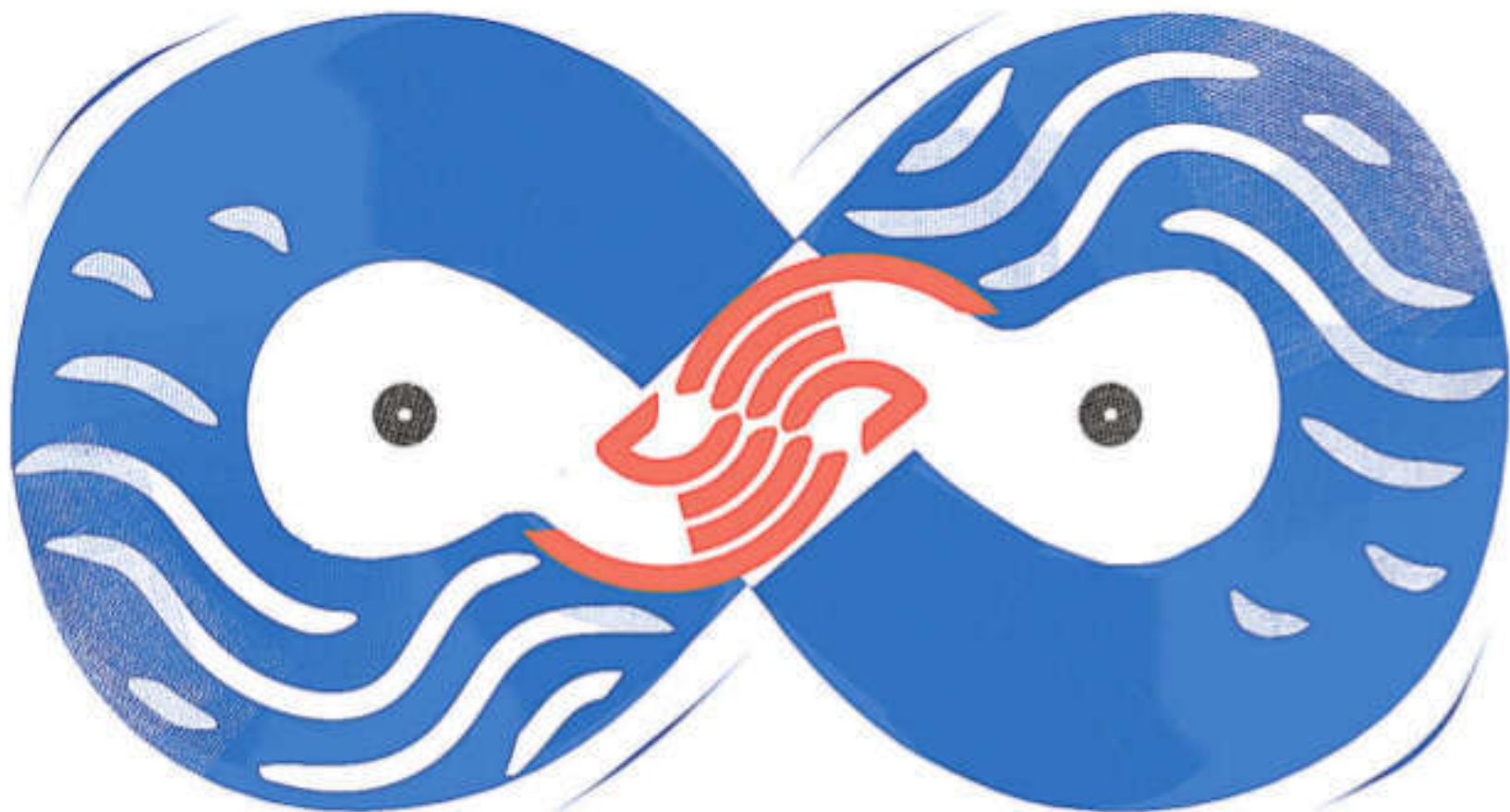


ILLUSTRATION: C R SASIKUMAR

towards India at home. In India, too, the federal politics surrounding Ganga water-sharing are no less complex. West Bengal's resistance prioritising its own needs and Bihar's allegations of siltation upstream of Farakka leading to floods will both pose challenges.

Second, the agenda has expanded beyond Farakka. Besides the Teesta, the recent protracted source of tension, disagreements over multiple shared rivers in the past three decades will impact the negotiations. Further, the concerns are unlikely to be just about water-resources sharing and development. The scope will expand to growing water-related risks, with greater uncertainty due to climate change. Climate change pushes the agenda beyond bilateral water allocations to regional-level responses to managing Himalayan glaciers, hydrological extremes, ecosystem resilience and shared vulnerabilities.

These changes have a few critical practical implications for the negotiations.

First, there is a need to avoid what political geographers call the "territorial trap" — the assumption that negotiations occur between the two sovereigns, represented by Delhi and Dhaka. Water diplomacy cannot be separated from internal diplomacy efforts, both in India

The 1996 treaty, signed after decades of deliberations, reflected a particular political moment of relatively stable bilateral relations. The treaty emerged from sustained Track 1 and Track 2 engagements that built trust and goodwill

and Bangladesh. Dhaka must figure out a way to navigate the polarised politics within. Further, posturing has its limits as a bargaining strategy. Signalling closer engagement with China in the Teesta basin may strengthen Bangladesh's negotiating position in the short term, but it also risks securitising negotiations and narrowing opportunities to explore mutual benefits. As the downstream riparian, Dhaka's long-term interests are better served through stable cooperation than through strategic posturing.

India, too, will need to invest in some amount of federal diplomacy despite the conducive equations after the recent elections in Bihar and West Bengal. Getting the states on board will not be easy. Water is an emotive subject and can offer opportunities for the parties in opposition to mobilise resistance from within.

Second, shared rivers create indispensable interdependencies — a less acknowledged but essential characteristic of transboundary rivers. It is not a zero-sum game when water-sharing considerations accompany those of coping with collective risks. The negotiations must build on this for an enduring bilateral relationship. The interdependencies may not always be bilateral. They may transcend to

become regional in character. Framing it as interdependencies shifts the focus to shared gains. Better management of floods, fisheries, inland navigation for trade, improved flood forecasting, and joint ecological restoration efforts could create benefits that extend beyond questions of water allocation.

Third, an enabling response to the first two is to invest in institutional avenues. Both India and Bangladesh will need to invest in appropriate institutional processes to channel polarised domestic politics in support of negotiations. Bilateral institutions need revisiting as well. Earlier institutional choices of the overarching Joint Rivers Commission and the Joint Committee for implementing the Ganga Treaty will not be adequate. They were conceived to implement agreements, not to manage uncertainties. The changed realities and greater uncertainties, including water availability, will need robust and resilient transborder institutions to address the enhanced scope of issues — water sharing, data collection and monitoring, dispute resolution, responding to risks, etc.

Finally, both countries will have to reinvent the political capital that made the 1996 treaty possible, and reinvest in it. The treaty negotiations can be a means to do it. Alongside Track 1 diplomacy, both countries should encourage Track 2 dialogues to generate ideas, sustain dialogue and build intellectual and political constituencies to support the dialogue. The 1996 treaty benefitted from such engagement. The Centre for Policy Research was among those at the forefront of such initiatives and contributed to developing a working draft of the treaty.

The negotiations can offer an opportunity to revisit the regional vision that India and Bangladesh jointly championed when SAARC was conceived. The institutional form may have to evolve beyond SAARC, but the underlying strategic rationale has become stronger. The next Ganga Treaty, therefore, presents an opportunity not merely to renew a bilateral water-sharing arrangement but to reimagine a regional strategic vision to address challenges of this new age of shared vulnerabilities and fragmented global economy.

The writer is president and chief executive, Centre for Policy Research, New Delhi. Views are personal

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Deterrence has broken down in West Asia



SHIBASHIS CHATTERJEE

THE US and Iran have been at odds since the 1979 Revolution, portraying each other as agents of violence or destruction. But this kind of mutual "othering" has not led to war; for all the posturing there has been deterrence, and a good deal of indirect negotiation, conducted with the necessary restraint. Identity is part of why the rivalry has held on, but it does not explain why things come to a head in direct military terms at some junctures and not at others.

For decades, Washington has worked to stymie any regional power that might challenge its hold on the Persian Gulf. Meanwhile, Iran has been building up its missile arsenal and its network of armed allies, edging closer to nuclear threshold status. In the eyes of the US, intervention may well be required to forestall an unfavourable change in the regional balance.

Tehran has a very different read on the same situation. It does not view American sanctions and bases, nor the military presence and ties with Israel and the Gulf monarchies, as mere deterrence or defensive measures. Instead, it sees them as a containment plot or, worse, an attempt at regime change. Neither side thinks of itself as the aggressor, yet both end up in a spiralling conflict. That is the security dilemma in a nutshell.

One would be hard pressed to see it as a 1914-style chain-gang. In 1914, chain-ganging described the way that rigid, interlocking alliance commitments quite literally chained the major powers of Europe to one another and pulled them into a worldwide war over an isolated Balkan quarrel. Washington and Tehran have not let go of the reins entirely; both still hold considerable leeway when it comes to calibrating escalation. Allies and their proxies can apply pressure, but it is the leaders who make the call on whether to intervene and to what extent.

In that light, conflict should be seen less as reflexive entrapment and more as a contest over projects led by competing regional orders. The US wants to keep a Middle East propped up by American power, Israeli might and connections with Arab auto-

crats. Iran, for its part, is intent on creating a zone where American influence has been largely neutralised and political power is in the hands of states and movements that are turning their backs on Washington.

This is no simple matter of short-term security or a dispute over territory. It is a war to establish who will set the rules and hierarchies and be recognised as the true centre of power. Wars ultimately hinge on calculations of deterrence.

Deterrence is only as strong as the other side's commitment to its red lines and its resolve to retaliate. When that is called into question, a leader may feel justified in a limited strike to put right any credibility deficit, imagining he can avoid an uncontrollable escalation. But it is a dangerous assumption. It makes the use of force seem like a sustainable option to both sides, each thinking it is restoring deterrence when in fact they are tearing down the old constraints that kept the rivalry from becoming direct conflict.

So this war is not the result of some ancient hatred or a case of being trapped by one's allies. At root, it is a symptom of a larger problem: The failure of a mechanism of controlled hostility. Washington and Tehran have been vying for decades without coming to blows. The balance was tenuous, but it held because they knew they would be the ones to suffer if things went off the rails. They have not suddenly found cause to be at each other's throats; they have had reason enough for that. What has altered is the calculus on the cost of waiting, the credibility of red lines and the shape of the regional order to come.

Globalisation has seen to it that the technologies underpinning Western military strength are now widely diffused. Iran's ability to put shipping in the Strait of Hormuz in jeopardy makes it plain that the most powerful countries can no longer rely on their preponderance of force to achieve political or commercial ends. In an era when power is more about disruption than destruction, the diffusion of technology is wearing away at the advantages of dominant states. The current war is therefore best explained as a crisis of deterrence within a broader struggle to define the Middle East, where the mechanisms of traditional containment are evidently gone.

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ILLUSTRATION: TANUSHRI MITRA

France, Spain race to curb wildfires before new heatwave arrives

Bordeaux, Madrid: Firefighters sought on Monday to take advantage of more favourable weather conditions to subdue massive wildfires threatening the French city and tourist region of Bordeaux and a number of sites in neighbouring Spain. They were racing against the clock as another heatwave is expected to hit both countries later this week in what has been a blisteringly hot and dry summer across Western Europe. Authorities have evacuated about 220,000 people, including holidaymakers and local residents, in France, while further south in Spain around 100,000 have been told to leave their homes or seek shelter. Prime Minister Sebastien Lecornu said France was going through an ‘unprecedented fire season’, with the area burned already having surpassed the previous record year of 2022. “The fight against wildfires begins with prevention. Nine out of 10 fires are human-caused and arise from carelessness: a cigarette butt, a barbecue, work carried out without precaution,” he wrote on X. **REUTERS**

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A plane drops fire retardant as firefighters battle wildfires near Marcheprime in France on Monday. **REUTERS**

LATEST PROJECTION IS NEARLY DOUBLE THE GOVT'S EARLIER ESTIMATE OF 13.56 GW

AI data centres' power load seen 26.3 GW by 2031-32

Pratyush Deep
New Delhi, July 27

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE (AI) data centres will put an additional load of 26.3 gigawatts (GW) by 2031-32, the Ministry of Power informed the Parliament on Monday. This additional load is expected to be integrated into the grid and will primarily be served by renewable energy capacity, the ministry added. The fresh projection is almost double the government's earlier projection in March this year when it estimated that electricity demand from data centres will reach 13.56 GW by 2031-32.

The present estimate is based on projects received by different states to set up data centres as the ministry is also holding consultation with stakeholders such as state transmission utilities, distribution utilities and data centre developers, the ministry officials said. Discussions are going on regarding reliable power supply, requirement of transmission and grid balancing as power load from data centres could be very spiky and have sharp ramps.

Policy-level discussions have also been underway on locating data centres away

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DATA CENTRE EXPANSION

INDIA IS expected to witness a sharp increase in data centre capacity in the coming years

FROM a mere 375 MW data centre capacity in 2020, the country's capacity stood at around 1.5 GW by 2025

INDIA'S OPERATIONAL data centre capacity will increase to 12 GW by 2030, growing at a CAGR of about 40%, says a report by Wood Mackenzie

THE EXPANDING digital econ-



omy is exerting unprecedented demand for data centre capacity in India

Real Creator IAS Edition https://t.me/+2RvD_RGf9mljMzg1cussions said. These discussions came as the country is expected to witness a sharp increase in data centre capacity in the coming years. From a mere 375 megawatt (MW) data centre capacity in 2020, India's current capacity stood at around 1.5 GW by 2025. According to a report by Wood Mackenzie, a global energy consultancy firm, India's operational data centre capacity will increase to 12 GW by 2030, at a compound annual growth rate (CAGR) of approximately 40%. "AI-dedicated capacity is expected to expand nearly 24-fold

over the same period, rising from 275 MW to 6,546 MW, as hyperscale cloud providers, enterprise digitalisation and artificial intelligence accelerate demand for computer infrastructure," it said in a statement on Monday.

The report claimed India's expanding digital economy is underpinning unprecedented demand for data centre capacity. "Valued at INR 32 trillion in 2025 and contributing approximately 12% of GDP, the country's digital ecosystem serves more than 1.03 billion active internet users and processes around 22 billion UPI transactions each month. Meanwhile, India's domestic AI market is projected to reach INR 11.7 trillion by 2032, further increasing demand for high-performance computing infrastructure," it said.

Data centre electricity demand is forecast to grow 20-fold by 2040 from 10 TWh in 2025 and would account for 7% of the total electricity demand, it added.

While AI runs on algorithms, it also requires electricity in large volumes. So, sector experts, too, had earlier expressed concerns over grid risks associated with these huge data centre loads. **FULL REPORT ON**

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Special forex drive raised \$32 billion so far, SBI predicts \$80-85 billion

Siddharth Upasani
New Delhi, July 27

INDIAN BANKS and companies have so far pulled in \$32 billion from the Reserve Bank of India's (RBI's) ongoing drive to raise money from abroad, with Governor Sanjay Malhotra saying total inflows are "likely to be robust".

Meanwhile, Soumya Kanti Ghosh, State Bank of India's (SBI's) Group Chief Economic Adviser, said in a report on Monday that up to \$85 billion may be raised in total through the concessional swap window for Foreign Currency Non-Resident (Bank) deposits, External Commercial Borrowings (ECBs), and Overseas Foreign Currency Borrowings (OFCBs). "Till date, banks have mobilised almost \$32 billion. Obviously, most of it is coming through FCNR(B) deposits. The figures related to ECBs and OFCBs are lumpy," RBI Governor Sanjay Malhotra told *The Hindu Businessline* newspaper in an interview published on Monday.

"In addition, we have got more than \$7 billion inflows in

In 2013, the RBI's swap facilities had ended up raising around \$34 billion in total, with \$26 billion coming from FCNR(B) deposits

government securities since June 5 when the policy announcements with respect to government securities were made. At this pace, the total inflows are likely to be robust," he added.

After early jitters on how successful the special drive to raise money from abroad would be, inflows have picked up rapidly and may have already crossed the total amount that was raised in 2013, when potential tightening of US monetary policy and concerns about high inflation in India had spooked foreign investors and led to a sharp decline in the rupee's exchange rate.

In 2013, the RBI's swap facilities had ended up raising around \$34 billion in total, with \$26 billion coming from

FCNR(B) deposits. The three concessional swap facilities were announced by the RBI on June 5. The FCNR(B) scheme, under which the central bank will bear the full exchange rate hedging cost for fresh 3-5-year deposits, is available till September 30. Meanwhile, the swap facility for ECBs and OFCBs is open till December 31.

According to SBI's Soumya Kanti Ghosh, new FCNR(B) deposits under the swap scheme could be in the range of \$65 billion-\$70 billion. Including ECBs and OFCBs, the overall figure could be \$80 billion-\$85 billion.

The swap facilities announced by the RBI on June 5, along with the Centre's decision to exempt foreign investors from paying a withholding tax on their government bond investments as well as the removal of capital gains tax, led to an immediate revival in the rupee's fortunes, which was seemingly moving towards the 100-per-dollar mark after nearly breaching 97 in May as the war in West Asia hit sentiment hard. **FULL REPORT ON**

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RBI to trial Rs 3k or worth of Rs 10, Rs 20 plastic notes

New Delhi: The Reserve Bank of India's (RBI) trial of plastic notes will see the introduction of 100 crore pieces of Rs 10 and Rs 20 notes each, worth a total of Rs 3,000 crore, Minister of State for Finance Pankaj Chaudhary said in response to a question in Lok Sabha on Monday.

Chaudhary said following a recommendation from its central board, the RBI had sent a proposal to the Centre for the field trials "and for regular issuance of polymer banknotes in these two denominations after successful completion of field trials".

The proposal was approved by the government.

The MoS in the finance ministry added that according to the RBI, the polymer banknotes are proposed to be issued along with paper banknotes and "there is no proposal to replace paper currency with polymer substrate-based banknotes".

The mention of the two denominations of banknotes is the first official confirmation of which notes will be targeted in the RBI's field trials. **ENS**

'No assessment done on share of vehicles fully compliant with E20'

Sukalp Sharma
New Delhi, July 27

NO ASSESSMENT has been done on the percentage of petrol vehicles in India that are fully compliant with E20 fuel, petrol blended with 20% ethanol, the government informed the Parliament on Monday. The information was provided by Minister of State for Petroleum and Natural Gas Suresh Gopi in response to a question in the Rajya Sabha. It comes amid a public backlash on ethanol-blended petrol.

"Ministry of Heavy Industries (MHI) have informed that no such assessment has been done by them," Gopi said in a written response in the Upper House. The MHI is the nodal ministry for the automobile sector in India. The country achieved 20% ethanol blending in petrol last year and at present, the E20 fuel — 80 parts petrol and 20 parts ethanol — is the standard petrol variant. There has been a public backlash over the E20 fuel, with claims ranging from notable reduction in mileage and engine component wear and tear in older vehicles whose engines were not designed for higher ethanol blends. As per

auto industry insiders, petrol vehicles manufactured and sold after April 2023 are considered fully E20-compliant as this was mandated under Bharat Stage 6 phase two emission norms. This means that all vehicles currently being sold by manufacturers are fully compliant with E20, but most vehicles that were sold prior to 2023 are not. The permissible life of a petrol vehicle in NCR is 15 years, which means that cars manufactured in 2022 can be in use till 2037, as per the current norms.

As per the government, E20 fuel can reduce fuel economy by 3-5% in older vehicles whose engines are not designed for this blend, it is cleaner and superior in other performance parameters vis-a-vis pure petrol and lower ethanol-petrol blends. On its part, the Centre has been trying to allay fears, saying that the drop in mileage in older vehicles will be marginal, and be outweighed by benefits like higher octane rating, superior anti-knock characteristics, faster combustion, better pickup, smoother acceleration and cleaner engine operation. **FULL REPORT ON**

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BoB reports 1 TB data breach, launches probe

Mumbai: Bank of Baroda (BoB) on Monday said it had suffered a data breach, with hackers accessing certain data and publishing it online.

"We hereby inform you of a cybersecurity incident involving Bank of Baroda. The bank received a communication from an anonymous source claiming access to certain data," BoB said.

The bank promptly activated its cyber incident response and containment protocols and engaged an independent CERT-In-empanelled cyber-security agency to con-

duct a comprehensive assessment and investigate the nature and extent of the alleged compromise, it said in an exchange filing.

Around 1 TB of data was reportedly made available on the dark web for free.

Based on the preliminary findings available at this stage, the incident has been identified as a potential business email compromise and is not expected to have any material impact on the bank's operations, financial performance, or business continuity, the bank said. **ENS**

